

The Problems with Coming Out in the Philippines (Final Project Write Up)

Coming out of the closet or coming out is the process where a non-heterosexual cisgender person becomes aware of his sexual orientation or gender identity and discloses it to the public for their reference (Rasmussen, 2004). Coming out has been a common practice for people who do not identify as “straight” – lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer, intersex, and asexual (Coming Out, 2021). Sounds easy, right? Unfortunately, coming out does not only mean being loud and proud of one’s identity. It involves risks and changes in the life of the person who comes out when, where, and how. In this exposition, I will demonstrate how coming out in the Philippines is disadvantageous for the Filipino LGBTQIA community and what is the role of social psychology in making coming out a positive experience.

Despite the inclusion of the Philippines in one of the world’s gay-friendly countries, coming out may be a traumatizing experience for some. The Philippines is a predominantly Catholic nation. Doctrine and teachings of Catholicism is taught as early as a child’s baptism. This early exposure to the tenets of Catholicism influences the *The “I” and The “Me”* of a person – how he sees himself, what values he upholds, and how he thinks (Biswas-Diener et al., 2017). As a result, an individual learns that there are only two genders in this world created by God – a man and a woman. Everyone who does not fall within this binary is peculiar, mysterious, and terrifying. This is the beginning of how coming out is not only problematic, but also dangerous.

Since time immemorial, LGBTQIA people are favorite subjects of prejudice, stereotyping, and discrimination. According to Plous (2003), humans’ natural inclination to *think categorically* drives the person to think prejudicially, and act on those thoughts. The teachings of Catholicism about the binary of gender have resulted to marginalization and oppression of LGBTQIA people. Since people cannot categorize LGBTQIA people between man and woman, this creates an internal dissonance that makes them hypervigilant and in a fight-or-flight response even if the non-heterosexual person is doing nothing to them. Efforts by the Church like mentioning LGBTQIA in homilies and releasing statements that malign LGBTQIA people also contributes to the perpetuation of the idea the LGBTQIA people are dangerous people. This gets *assimilated* in the negative prejudgments that already formed in the mind of perpetrators. This is supported in the study conducted by Belous and colleagues (2015) which found that gay men living in conservative roofs are more likely to experience negative stereotyping from family members. Accusation of promiscuity, being sexual predators, and an embarrassment to the name of the family are the general stereotypes they receive. Aside from their families, people who come out are treated harshly and become victims of homophobic attitudes in the community where education and income are scarce (McGarrity, 2014). The same thing is true for LGBT employees who are more likely to not be considered for promotion even if they meet the criteria (Marrs & Statton, 2016). Clearly, coming out in religious communities increases susceptibility to prejudice and discrimination.

Aside from increasing susceptibility to discrimination, coming is problematic because it’s a lifelong process. For this reason, prejudice and discrimination are part of LGBTQIA people’s lives. Hence, this impacts how LGBTQIA people see themselves as social actors. According to Biswas-Diener and colleagues (2017), the *self as a social actor* may be construed in terms of their traits and social roles. When an individual’s identity is stigmatized, this taints his *social reputation* and his *self-esteem*. For instance, lesbian women who came out in their middle adulthood had a hard time recovering their self-esteem and credibility as experts in their career. The prejudice and stereotypes people hold about them replace all the traits and social roles they perform. In other words, people see them solely as their sexual orientation (Rickards and Wuest, 2006).

It is a popular belief that coming out is uniformly healthy. This is a bluff. According to McGarrity and Huebner (2013), coming out contributes to psychological well-being of gay and

bisexual men who belong to high income group, while it gay and bisexual men who came out in lower income groups experienced more negative health outcomes such as substance use, risky behaviors, and mental health challenges to mention some. Additionally, transgender people, particularly transgender women who became homeless after familial rejection reported lower levels of self-esteem (Schmitz & Tyler, 2017). Evidently, coming out has inverse effects on the psychological well being of LGBTQIA people living in lower income groups. Unfortunately, this may be the case of the Philippines as the majority of the people are living within and below the poverty line.

Given all this information, should LGBTQIA people still come out? Definitely. This is a way of reclaiming identity. However, should they decide to come out, there are three conditions that should be met.

First, LGBTQIA people should come out to people whom they have positive relationships with. *Positive relationship* is defined as a relationship that is beneficial and promotes well-being of persons. Positive relationship includes *active-constructive responding* which is the demonstration of sincere interest and enthusiasm of another person (Biswas-Diener et al., 2017). For example, parents who affirm their child's identity after coming out are more likely to show positive well-being (Price & Prosek, 2020). One can affirm an LGBTQIA child by checking in on them, inviting their romantic partners in family gatherings, and defending them against non-affirming family members. Furthermore, gay grandparents are more likely to maintain ties with grandchildren if they have developed a *relationship bank account* with their adult children that is filled with positive deposits (Fruhauf, Orel, & Jenkins, 2009).

Second, being part of a group helps in minimizing the negative effects of coming out. *Social identity theory* assumes that groups influence the self-concept and self-esteem of its members, especially those who classify with the group and pride in the identity of the group. According to Klein et al. (2014), Participating or membership in LGBTQIA organizations is associated with good psychological health outcomes. LGBTQIA youth reported that they feel seen, heard, and validated when participating in queer activities. Clearly, membership and identification with LGBTQIA groups increase *collective* and *individual self-esteem*.

Finally, a support system should be in place when one decides to come out. According to Biswas-Diener et al. (2017), social support is divided into two: received and perceived. *Received social support* refers to the actual helping of people around us, whereas the belief that help is available is called *perceived social support*. LGBTQIA students who came out in college were more likely to have positive well-being. Since college helped normalize LGBTQIA culture, LGBTQIA students were more likely to have high perceived and received social support. As a result, they are more likely to establish friendships, join student groups, become involved in advocacy projects, and develop romantic relationships (Price & Prosek, 2019). Meanwhile, living with chosen families help LGBTQIA youth, especially transgender people in improving their self-esteem (Schmitz & Tyler, 2017). The *sociometer model* states that an individual's level of self-esteem is the psychological indicator of inclusion or exclusion from the group. This supports the idea of chosen families. When one feels included, welcomed, and appreciated by the group, their self-esteem improves.

Indeed, coming out more than a personal process, is a social phenomenon. Although coming out is a heteronormative concept created for the LGBTQIA community, it cannot be denied that it provides some benefits to individuals who do it. The friendships formed, the validation felt, and memories shared with friends, family, and people who support and accept a person's individuality are worth it. However, it is my hope that no should come out in the future. No one has to come out because a person's sexual orientation, gender identity, and expression is not a mystery, but rather his truth that everyone accepts. **#HappyPride**

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